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Tesla asks shareholders to approve \$29B comp package for Elon Musk amid 'AI talent war'

Sean O'Kane — 4:13 AM PDT · August 4, 2025

Tesla's board of directors has announced a proposed compensation package for CEO Elon Musk that would be worth around \$29 billion in shares, with the company citing the "ever-intensifying AI talent war and Tesla's position at a critical inflection point" as reasons for the payout.

The new plan will be put to a vote at the company's annual shareholder meeting, which is scheduled for November. It will also be entirely voided if the Delaware Supreme Court decides to overturn a judge's [January 2024 decision](#) to strike down Musk's 2018 compensation package because of how it was negotiated behind the scenes.

Musk has threatened to stop working on AI and robotics at Tesla [unless he gains more control over the company](#). Those threats preceded what is now a multi-million dollar talent war among the [biggest companies in the artificial intelligence space](#), along with a rush of mergers and acquisitions. Musk has simultaneously built up his own AI company outside Tesla called xAI, which now owns X, his social media platform.

Tesla [said](#) Monday that its board of directors formed a special committee earlier this year consisting of chairwoman Robyn Denholm and board member Kathleen

The award they ultimately received was worth 1.5 million shares that will vest over the next five years. Unlike Tesla's other awards, this one does not appear to be tied to performance.

At Tesla's Monday announcement, Musk valued the \$29 billion. Musk valued the package at \$29 billion, bringing the total compensation to \$1.5 billion. Depending on the appeal, the package could dip,' according to Tesla.

"Elon will not be able to keep this new award in addition to the options he will be awarded under the 2018 CEO Performance Award should the courts rule in our favor," the company wrote.

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Tesla said Musk and his brother Kimbal, who is also a board member, recused themselves from the process of constructing this new compensation package. Musk’s involvement in the 2018 compensation package, which was worth around \$56 billion, was one of the reasons why Delaware Chancery Court judge chancellor Kathaleen McCormick [decided to strike it down](#) following a trial sparked by a shareholder lawsuit.

McCormick said the process of creating that 2018 plan was “deeply flawed” because of Musk’s input and his deep connections to the people on Tesla’s board. She also criticized that plan for not including any terms that would bind Musk to Tesla for “any set amount of time” — a likely reason for the two-year pledge included in the new plan.

McCormick’s decision caused an uproar among Tesla’s largest fans and many of its shareholders. It’s also what inspired the company to re-incorporate from Delaware to Texas. McCormick’s decision was a shareholder protest, a shareholder vote, and a shareholder lawsuit. McCormick [confirmed her decision](#) after a hearing on legal arguments with Tesla. McCormick’s decision is the latest in a series of legal strains of settled lawsuits.

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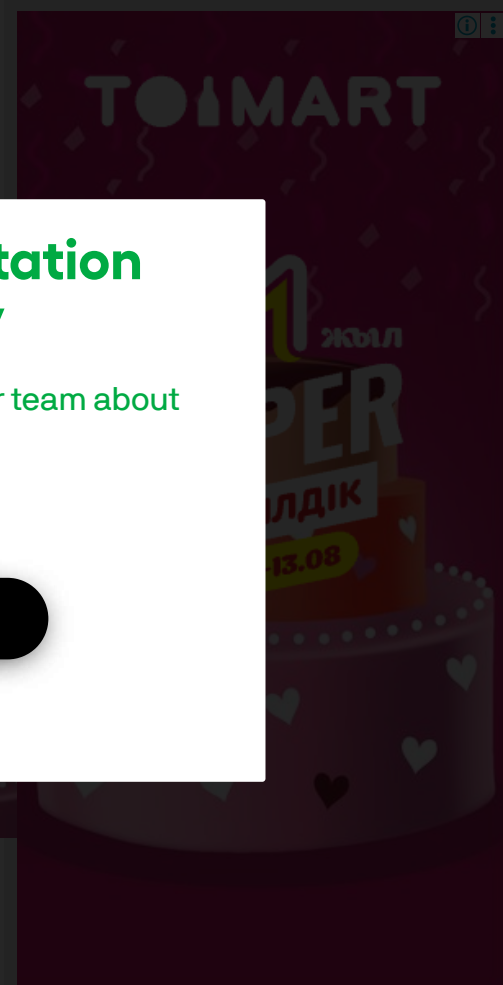
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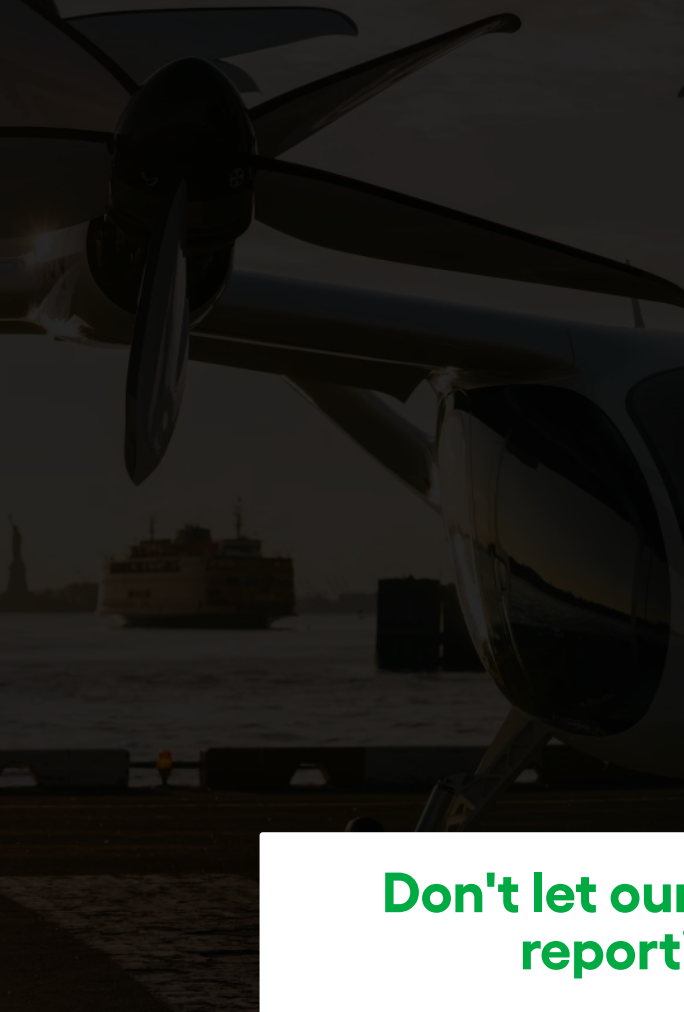
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Electric air taxi developer Blade Air Mobility's helicopter ride-share business

Joby is buying the ride-share business of Blade Air Mobility, which includes operations in New York City. Blade's founder and CEO Rob Wiesenthal will continue to lead the business, which will operate as a wholly-owned subsidiary of Joby.

Blade's medical division, which transports organs, isn't included in the transaction and will remain a separate company.

The deal gives Joby instant access to a network of 12 terminals in key markets like New York City — notably, a dedicated lounge as well as terminal bases at John F. Kennedy International Airport, Newark Liberty Airport, the West Side of Manhattan, the East Side of Manhattan, and Wall Street.

Blade, founded in 2014, doesn't own a fleet of aircraft. Instead, the company has developed a digital network that allows passengers to book private rides on helicopters across several short-hop routes. The service has grown in popularity as well-heeled customers seek out ways to avoid traffic on their commutes from the suburbs into Manhattan, or to The Hamptons for weekends and holidays. The company, which also offers

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access to routes from Nice, France, to Monaco and Saint-Tropez, flew more than 50,000 passengers in 2024.

Joby Aviation founder and CEO JoeBen Bevirt described the deal as a “strategically important” acquisition that will support its launch of its commercial operations in Dubai and subsequent global rollout. The company said it will integrate its software, which is designed to manage air taxi operations, into Blade’s passenger service.

Joby, founded in 2009 by Bevirt, has been working for more than a decade to develop, certify and produce an electric vertical take off and landing (eVTOL) aircraft for commercial taxi service in cities. (The company is also pursuing a separate [defense-related business](#).) Eventually, the branded Blade service will use electric air taxis, not helicopters in its service, according to the companies.

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TechCrunch is excited to host these voices, and we’re looking forward to the event before the year is over.

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Toyota-backed Joby Aviation has secured a \$1.5 billion investment from a new Technology Partner, according to a filing with the SEC. The deal, which was announced on LinkedIn co-founder Reid Hoffman and Zynga founder Mark Pincus.

Under terms of the agreement, Joby is holding back \$35 million of the purchase price, which will be released if Blade hits certain performance milestones and retains certain key employees.

Topics: [air taxis](#) [blade air mobility](#) [Joby Aviation](#) [Mergers and Acquisitions](#)

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Sean O'Kane — 11:24 AM PDT · August 1, 2025

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A jury in federal court in Miami has found Tesla partly to blame for a fatal 2019 crash that involved the use of the company’s Autopilot driver assistance system.

The jury assessed punitive damages only against Tesla, [CNBC reported](#). The punitive fines coupled with a compensatory damages puts the total payments to around \$242.5 million. The plaintiff’s attorney confirmed to TechCrunch that this is the correct amount.

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Neither the driver of the car nor the Autopilot system braked in time to avoid going through an intersection, where the car struck an SUV and killed a pedestrian. The jury assigned the driver two-thirds of the blame, and attributed one-third to Tesla. (The driver was sued separately.)

The verdict comes at the end of a three-week trial over the crash, which killed 20-year-old Naibel Benavides Leon and severely injured her boyfriend Dillon Angulo. The verdict is one of the first major legal decisions about driver assistance technology that has gone against Tesla. The company has previously settled lawsuits [involving similar claims about Autopilot](#).

Brett Schreiber, the lead attorney for the plaintiffs in the case, said in a statement to TechCrunch that Tesla designed Autopilot “only for controlled access highways yet deliberately chose not to restrict drivers from using it elsewhere, alongside Elon Musk telling the world Autopilot drove better than humans.”

“Tesla’s lies turned our roads into test tracks for their fundamentally flawed technology, putting everyday Americans like Naibel Benavides and Dillon Angulo at risk,” Schreiber said. “This verdict represents justice for the victims and their families, and is holding Tesla and its executives accountable for the loss of lives.”

Tesla, in a statement, said the verdict “given the

“Today’s verdict is a blow to Tesla and its investors, and jeopardize Tesla’s ability to implement life-saving technology in its cars. Tesla has never about Autopilot; it was a fiction concocted by plaintiffs’ lawyers blaming the car when the driver — from day one — admitted and accepted responsibility.”

Tesla and Musk spent years making claims about Autopilot’s capabilities that have led to overconfidence in the driver assistance system, a reality that government officials — and Musk himself — have spoken about for years.

The National Transportation Safety Board (NTSB) came to this determination in 2020 after investigating a 2018 crash where the driver died after hitting a concrete barrier. That driver, Walter Huang, was [playing a mobile game while using Autopilot](#). The NTSB made a number of recommendations following that investigation, which [Tesla largely ignored](#), the [safety board later claimed](#).

On a 2018 conference call, Musk said “complacency” with driver assistance systems like Autopilot is a problem.

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“They just get too used to it. That tends to be more of an issue. It’s not a lack of understanding of what Autopilot can do. It’s [drivers] thinking they know more about Autopilot than they do,” Musk [said at the time](#).

The trial took place at a time when Tesla is currently in the [middle of rolling out the first versions of its long-promised Robotaxi network](#), starting in Austin, Texas. Those vehicles are using an enhanced version of Tesla’s more capable driver assistance system, which it calls Full Self-Driving.

Update: This story has been updated to include the amount of compensatory damages in the total.

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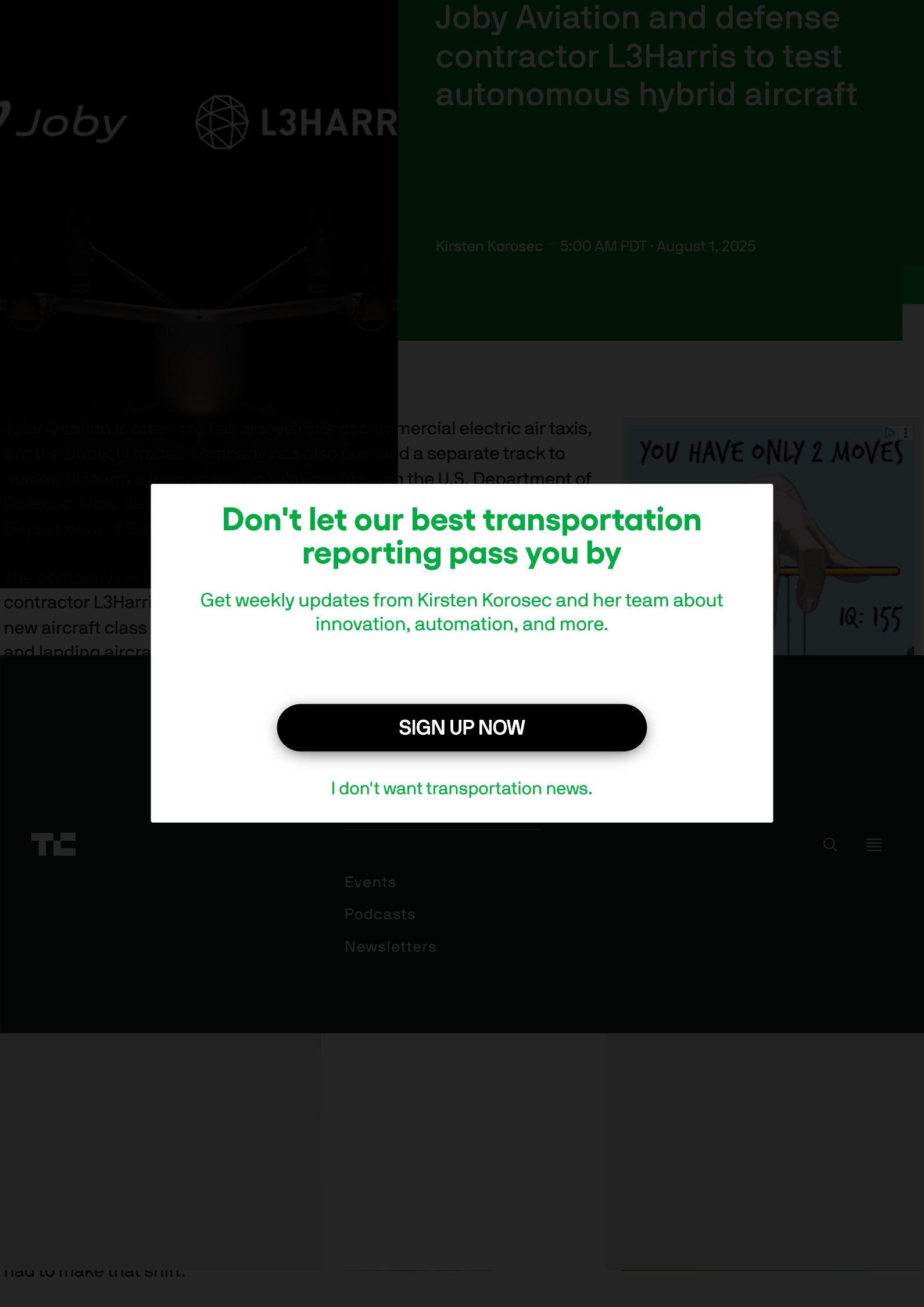
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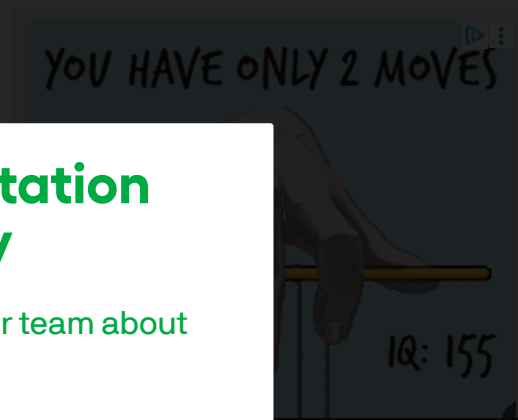
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Joby Aviation and defense contractor L3Harris to test autonomous hybrid aircraft

Kirsten Korosec — 5:00 AM PDT · August 1, 2025

Joby Aviation is often cast as a developer of commercial electric air taxis, but the publicly traded company has also pursued a separate track to market through a partnership with the U.S. Department of Defense. Now, its partnership with the U.S. Department of Defense has expanded to include a new aircraft class and landing aircraft.



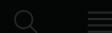
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Sciarra added it was also important to demonstrate the so-called “missionization of its platform” — how its aircraft could be combined with the right sensors, autonomy, communications and payload to provide a clear use case for the DoD.

“We have two choices: we can continue to be an incredible part of the ecosystem, or we can be a case study in how not to do it.”

That’s where L3Harris comes in.

Jon Rambeau, president of L3Harris, is leading the new vertical lift program, which includes teaming for a range of aircraft. The program could be used to develop aircraft that include contested environments, autonomous aircraft systems, and more.

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Ford to reveal more about its new low-cost electric vehicles on August 11

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Ford is set to reveal its new low-cost electric vehicles at its Investor Day on August 11. The company is talking a very big announcement is

Farley made the comments after Ford revealed its electric vehicle division posted a loss of around \$1.3 billion in the second quarter of 2025. Sales of the company's top two EVs, the F-150 Lightning and the Mustang Mach-E, are declining, all while things are looking increasingly tough for electric vehicles under the second Trump administration.

Farley first revealed that Ford had a skunkworks team developing a low-cost electric vehicle in February 2024. As TechCrunch first reported, the effort is being led by [former Tesla executive Alan Clarke](#), and the team is [brimming with talent](#) from companies like Tesla, Rivian, Apple, and Lucid Motors.

The company has been deliberately vague about any specifics, but has admitted that the first vehicle to be built on this new low-cost platform [will be a mid-size pickup truck](#) set for release in 2027. Ford has said it will build "multiple vehicle styles — for both retail and commercial customers" on the platform, and that these vehicles will feature "personalized digital experiences."

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Cheaper models could help Ford, but 2027 is still a long way out.

While there are basically no mass-market electric vehicles available in the U.S. at or under \$30,000, that likely won't be the case when Ford's secretive EVs hit the market in two years. Tesla has said it will start selling a stripped-down (and possibly smaller) Model Y SUV later this year. General Motors is [bringing back the Chevy Bolt next year](#). And Jeff Bezos-backed startup Slate Auto is putting its own [low-cost electric pickup on sale as early as late 2026](#).

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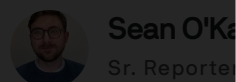
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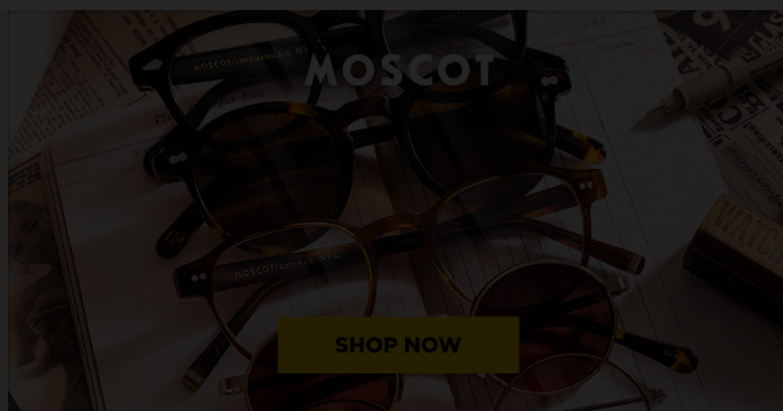


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